

Your Autistic Classmate / Friend

For primary-school peers, friends & their families — getting along with an autistic child (roughly ages 6–11).

The one idea

Autism, through **monotropism**, means a classmate's attention locks into a few deep, intense "tunnels." They might know *everything* about their special interest, take things very literally, need things to stay predictable, and get overwhelmed by noise or surprise — and then need a quiet moment to recover. None of that is weird or rude; it's just how their attention works. The good news: autistic kids often make **fantastic, loyal friends** — especially when you meet them around a shared interest and give them space to be themselves.

What you may see — and what's really going on

You may see...	What's often happening
Knows everything about one topic; talks about it a lot	A passion — and the best way to connect
Doesn't get jokes, sarcasm or hints	Takes things literally ; say what you mean
Wants the same game, the same rules, every time	Predictability feels safe — not "bossy"
Covers their ears, leaves, or goes quiet in the dining hall	Sensory overload — the noise is genuinely painful
Doesn't always answer or look at you	Looking away helps them listen; not rudeness

Try this

- **Connect through their interest** — ask about it, join in; it's their front door to friendship.
- **Say what you mean** — clear and literal beats hints and sarcasm.
- **Give a quiet option** at break and lunch — a calm spot to hang out together.
- **Warn before changes** — "five minutes, then we swap"; surprises are hard.
- **Be the accepting friend** — one real friend who "gets it" beats a crowd.

Avoid this

- Teasing, sarcasm, or "make eye contact" demands.
- Springing surprises, loud games or sudden changes on them.
- Reading a meltdown or a shutdown as them being "weird" or "rude."

When to get more support

If your friend is being bullied or left out, tell a trusted adult — autistic kids are often targeted, and one ally changes everything. If they have a meltdown, give them space and quiet, not an audience; tell a teacher if you're worried.

If your friend is a girl

Autistic girls often mask and may seem “quietly fine” while struggling; being a kind, low-pressure friend matters more than a busy social life.

About this guide

*AI-assisted, derived from this project's research drafts — **Growing Up Monotropic** (Part 1), the **Family guide** (Part 6) and the **Monotropism** brief. Uses identity-first language. **Informational — not a diagnostic tool.** Fit it to the individual child.*

Key sources. Murray, Lesser & Lawson (2005); Murray, F. (2023); Dwyer (2025); Milton (2012, double empathy); Reframing Autism (2023). Full citations are in the source drafts.